

18

A Lifetime Ruy Lopez System

A two-sided repertoire map, model rehearsals, and a method for updating theory through your own games.



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

You will leave able to study the Spanish from either chair, diagnose unfamiliar move orders, and repair one decision at a time.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate candidates for the side to move, identify the opponent's strongest resource, and choose the resulting structure you can explain. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 103 | PAGE 4

Decode: White's main-plan rehearsal

The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

LESSON 104 | PAGE 8

Play: White's main-plan rehearsal

The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

LESSON 105 | PAGE 12

Decode: Black's defense-choice tree

Every Spanish defense is a bargain; know both the asset and the debt.

LESSON 106 | PAGE 16

Play: Black's defense-choice tree

Every Spanish defense is a bargain; know both the asset and the debt.

LESSON 107 | PAGE 20

Decode: Repairing Spanish theory from games

Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.

LESSON 108 | PAGE 24

Play: Repairing Spanish theory from games

Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

You will leave able to study the Spanish from either chair, diagnose unfamiliar move orders, and repair one decision at a time.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: White's main-plan rehearsal



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White's durable plan links pressure on e5, c3-d4, bishop preservation, and knight rerouting; each move prepares the central release.

DECISION RULE

Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Black organizes a freeing break and challenges White's buildup before every piece reaches its ideal square.

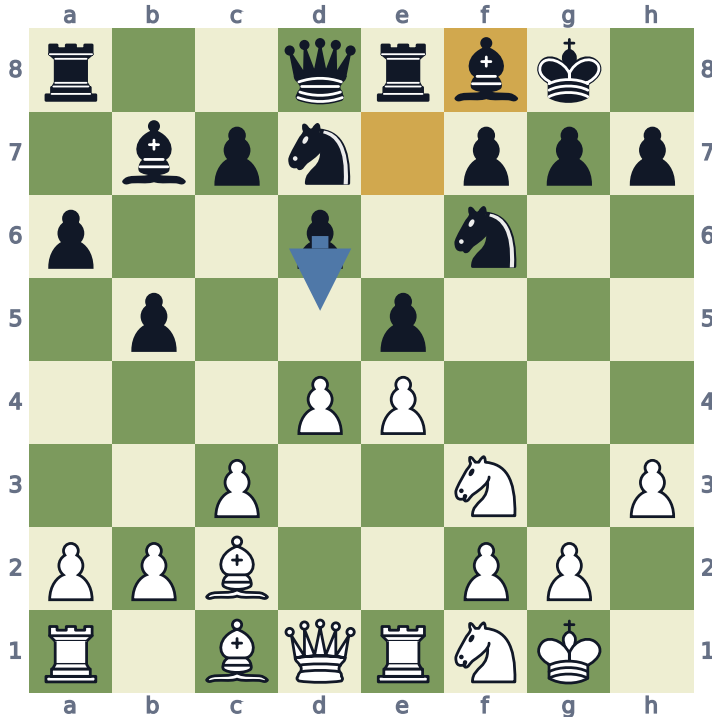
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White identifies the least active piece, improves it, and plays d4 only when the transformation helps the whole army.

MEMORY RULE | The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White's durable plan links pressure on e5, c3-d4, bishop preservation, and knight rerouting; each move prepares the central release.

BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White identifies the least active piece, improves it, and plays d4 only when the transformation helps the whole army.

FAILURE MODE

Reciting the full maneuvering script after the position has already demanded concrete action.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

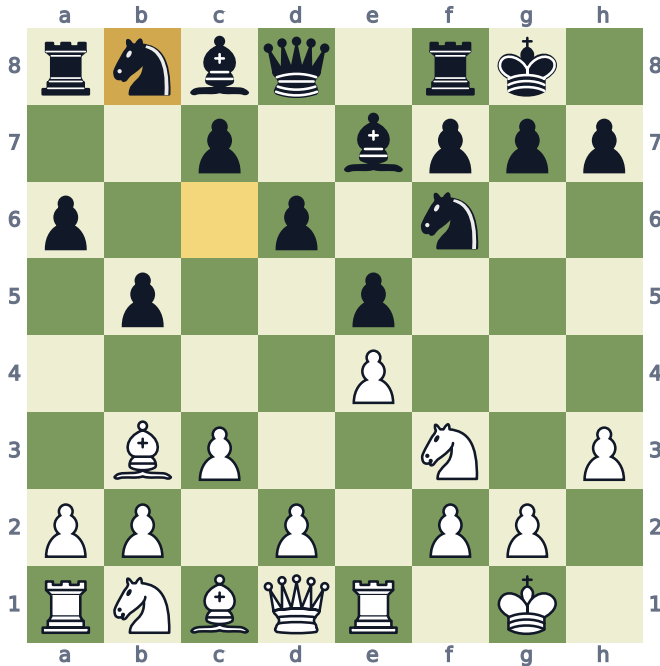
RULE | The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8 10. d4 Nbd7 11. Nbd2 Bb7 12. Bc2 Re8 13. Nf1 Bf8



- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Nb8: Black reroutes a knight to b8; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's durable plan links pressure on e5, c3-d4, bishop preservation, and knight rerouting; each move prepares the central release.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup? White's resource is: White identifies the least active piece, improves it, and plays d4 only when the transformation helps the whole army. The line fails as a template when: Reciting the full maneuvering script after the position has already demanded concrete action.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

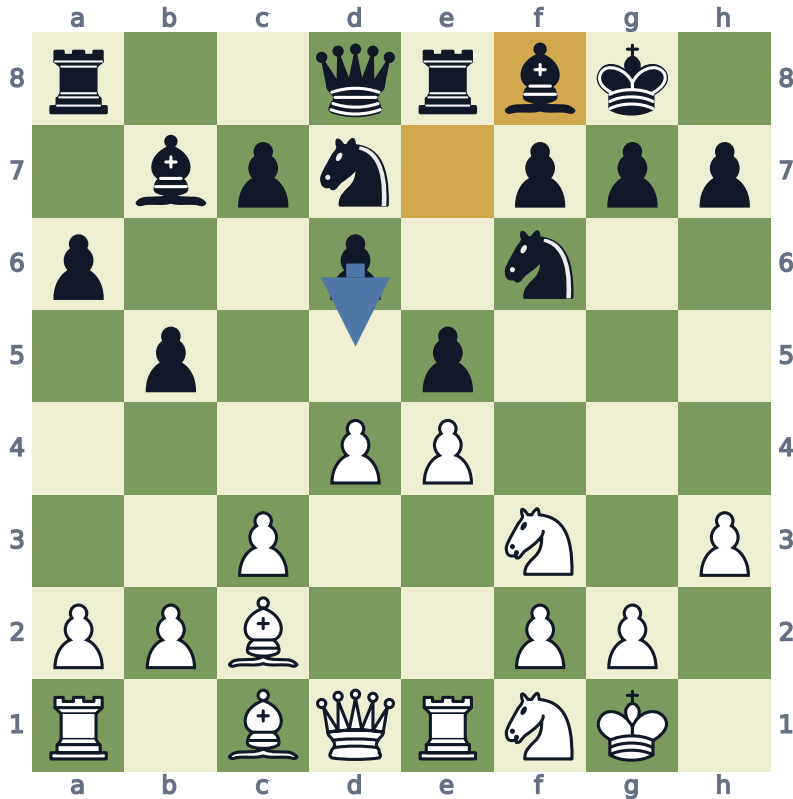
1. White's durable plan links pressure on e5, c3-d4, bishop preservation, and knight rerouting; each move prepares the central release. 2. Black organizes a freeing break and challenges White's buildup before every piece reaches its ideal square. 3. White identifies the least active piece, improves it, and plays d4 only when the transformation helps the whole army. 4. Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup? 5. Reciting the full maneuvering script after the position has already demanded concrete action.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 18 plies from memory, then replay: 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: White's main-plan rehearsal



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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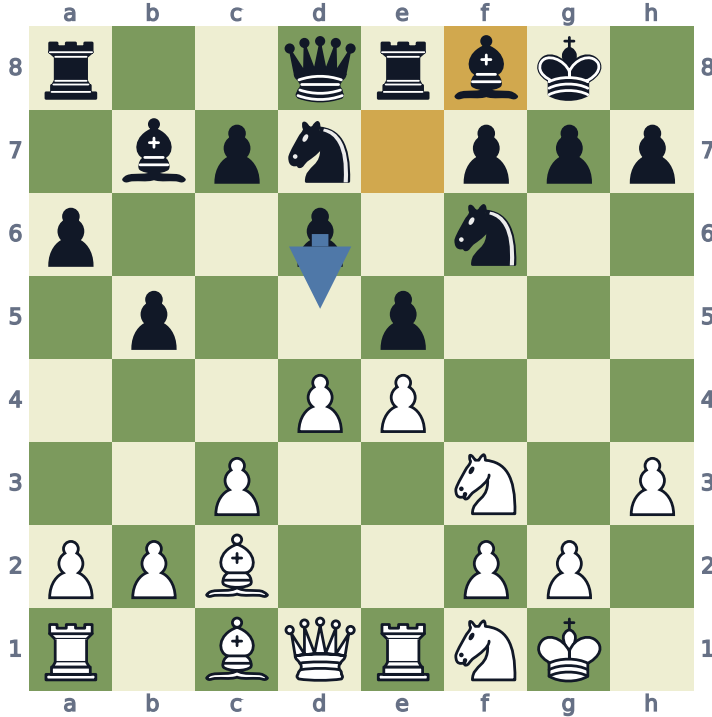
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MEMORY RULE | The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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Reciting the full maneuvering script after the position has already demanded concrete action.

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Ask: Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

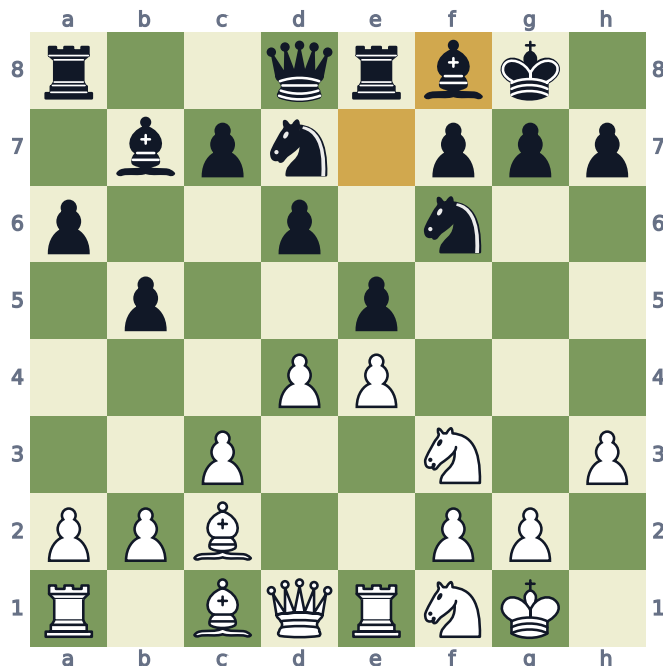
RULE | The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Nbd2: White reroutes a knight to d2; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bb7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Bc2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re8: Black places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- Nf1: White reroutes a knight to f1; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bf8: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White's durable plan links pressure on e5, c3-d4, bishop preservation, and knight rerouting; each move prepares the central release.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup? White's resource is: White identifies the least active piece, improves it, and plays d4 only when the transformation helps the whole army. The line fails as a template when: Reciting the full maneuvering script after the position has already demanded concrete action.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

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4. What exact question decides the next move?

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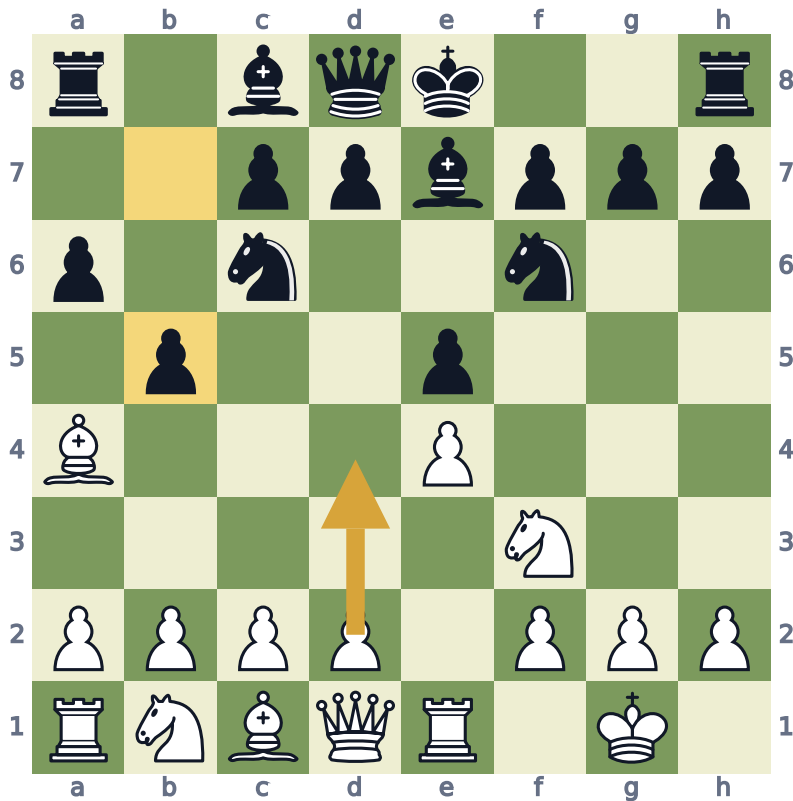
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 26 plies from memory, then replay: 11. Nbd2 Bb7 12. Bc2 Re8 13. Nf1 Bf8

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Black's defense-choice tree



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Black's major systems answer the same pressure differently: maintain e5, sacrifice with ...d5, enter a queenless Berlin, or activate through an Open Spanish center.

DECISION RULE

What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Choose a system whose strategic debt you accept, then play its coordinated package rather than mixing move fragments.

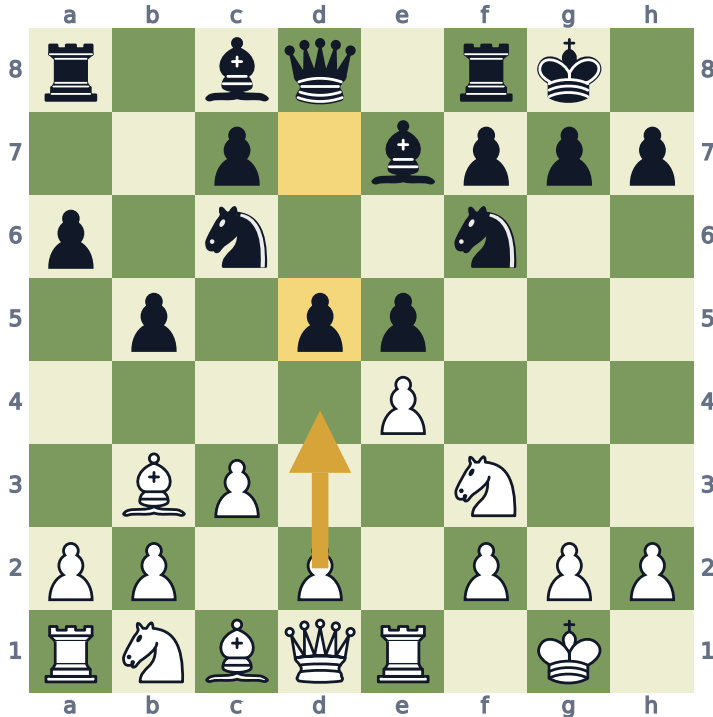
WHITE'S RESOURCES

White identifies the debt: weak squares, sacrificed pawn, uncastled king, or delayed development, and builds pressure against it.

MEMORY RULE | Every Spanish defense is a bargain; know both the asset and the debt.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

Black's major systems answer the same pressure differently: maintain e5, sacrifice with ...d5, enter a queenless Berlin, or activate through an Open Spanish center.

BLACK'S PLAN

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

White identifies the debt: weak squares, sacrificed pawn, uncastled king, or delayed development, and builds pressure against it.

FAILURE MODE

Selecting a defense by reputation while disliking the middlegames it intentionally creates.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

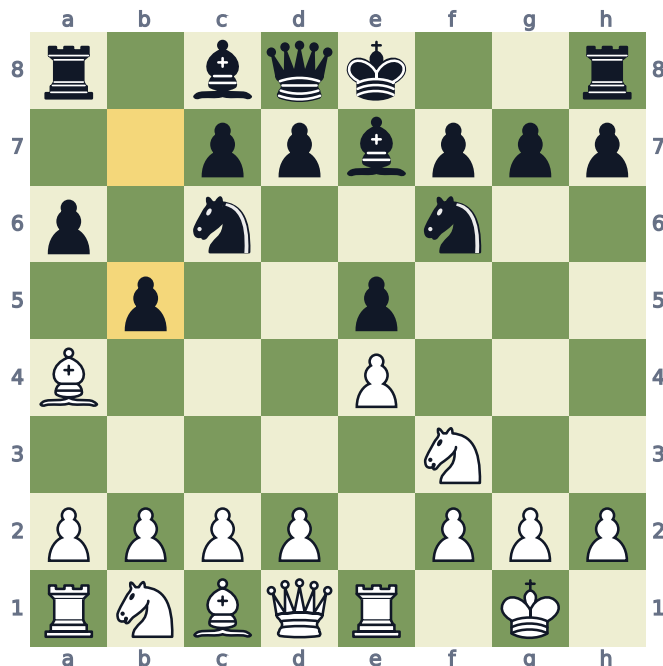
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d5



- Ba4: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Nf6: Black reroutes a knight to f6; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- O-O: White secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- Be7: Black changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's major systems answer the same pressure differently: maintain e5, sacrifice with ...d5, enter a queenless Berlin, or activate through an Open Spanish center.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used? White's resource is: White identifies the debt: weak squares, sacrificed pawn, uncastled king, or delayed development, and builds pressure against it. The line fails as a template when: Selecting a defense by reputation while disliking the middlegames it intentionally creates.

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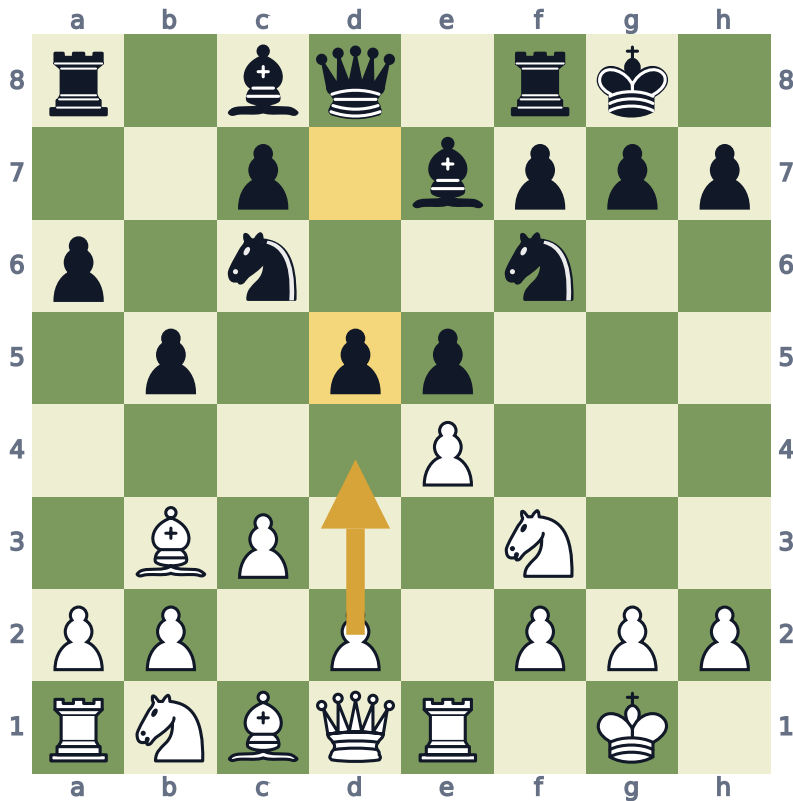
1. Black's major systems answer the same pressure differently: maintain e5, sacrifice with ...d5, enter a queenless Berlin, or activate through an Open Spanish center. 2. Choose a system whose strategic debt you accept, then play its coordinated package rather than mixing move fragments. 3. White identifies the debt: weak squares, sacrificed pawn, uncastled king, or delayed development, and builds pressure against it. 4. What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used? 5. Selecting a defense by reputation while disliking the middlegames it intentionally creates.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Black's defense-choice tree



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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DECISION RULE

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SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

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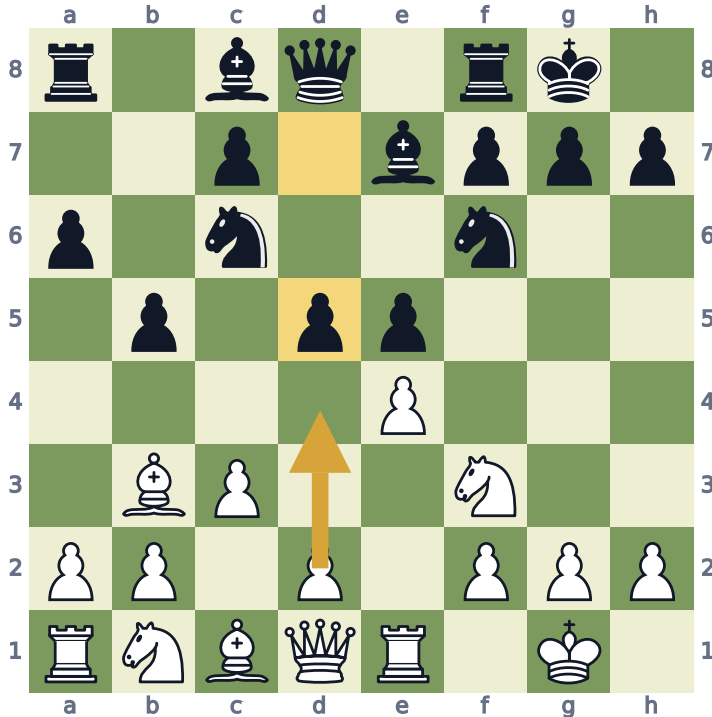
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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WHITE'S PLAN

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FAILURE MODE

Selecting a defense by reputation while disliking the middlegames it intentionally creates.

DECISION TEST

Ask: What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

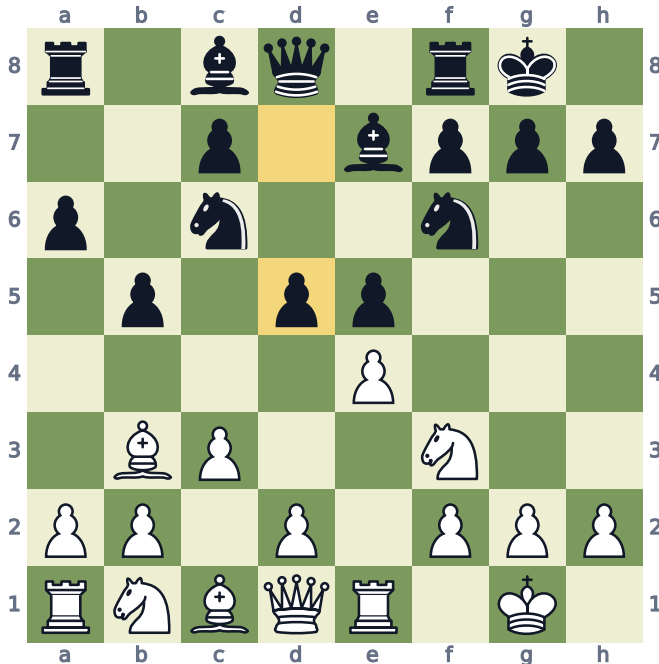
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d5



- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- O-O: Black secures the king and connects a rook; central and wing operations can now be judged more concretely.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
- d5: Black challenges the center or offers dynamic activity, depending on the system.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Black's major systems answer the same pressure differently: maintain e5, sacrifice with ...d5, enter a queenless Berlin, or activate through an Open Spanish center.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used? White's resource is: White identifies the debt: weak squares, sacrificed pawn, uncastled king, or delayed development, and builds pressure against it. The line fails as a template when: Selecting a defense by reputation while disliking the middlegames it intentionally creates.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

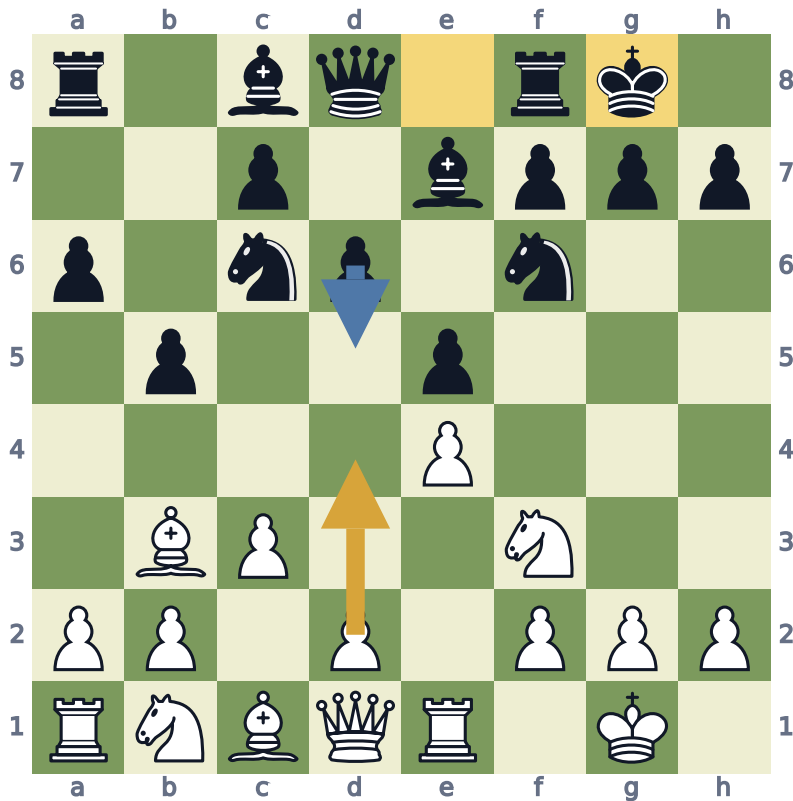
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d5

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Repairing Spanish theory from games



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

Because the Ruy Lopez branches deeply, efficient study begins at the first position where your plan became unclear, not at move one after every loss.

DECISION RULE

At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time?

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S RESOURCES

Record the structure, candidate moves, and strongest opponent reply; add one corrected line and one verbal rule to the repertoire.

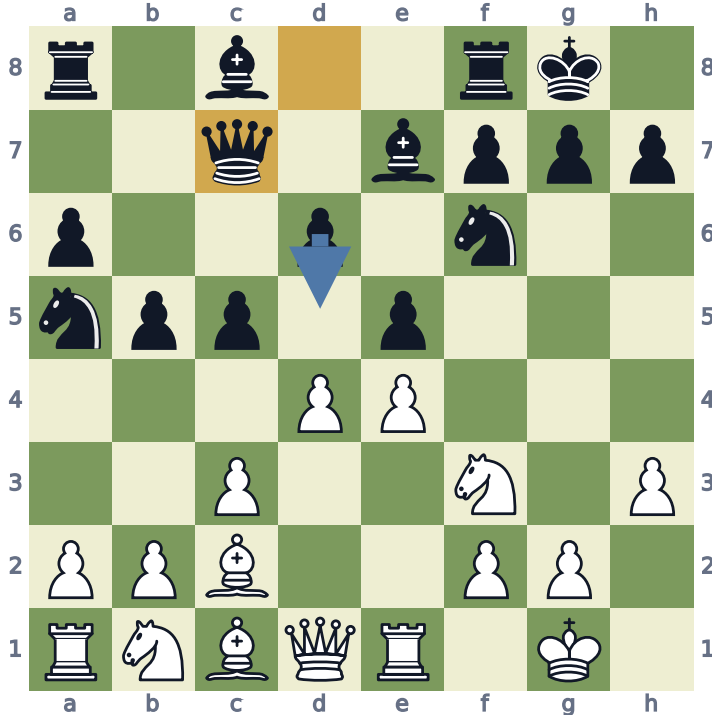
WHITE'S RESOURCES

Use both colors in training so opponent resources become familiar plans rather than surprises.

MEMORY RULE | Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S PLAN

Use both colors in training so opponent resources become familiar plans rather than surprises.

FAILURE MODE

Replacing understanding with ever-longer files or abandoning the opening after one tactical loss.

DECISION TEST

Ask: At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time? Then compare at least two candidates against the opponent's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

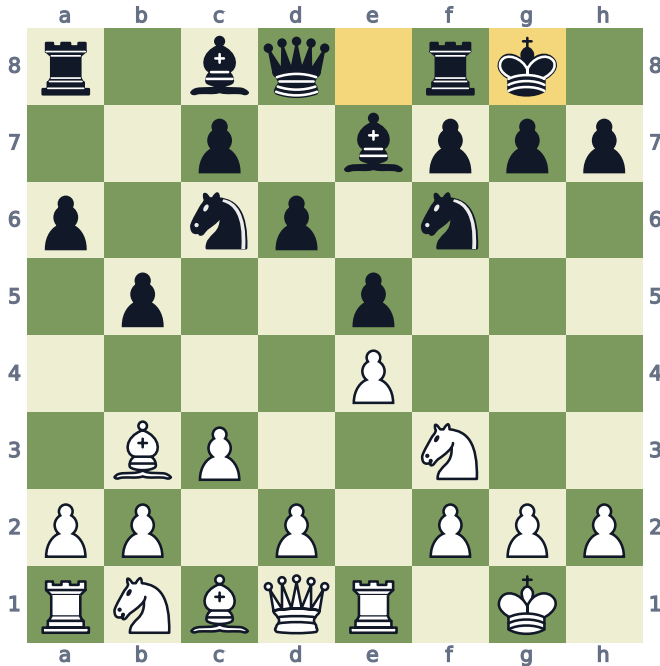
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Re1: White places a rook behind a file or pawn break expected to become important.
- b5: Black gains bishop tempo and queenside space while creating a possible pawn target.
- Bb3: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- c3: White supports d4 and reserves c2 as a retreat square for the Spanish bishop.
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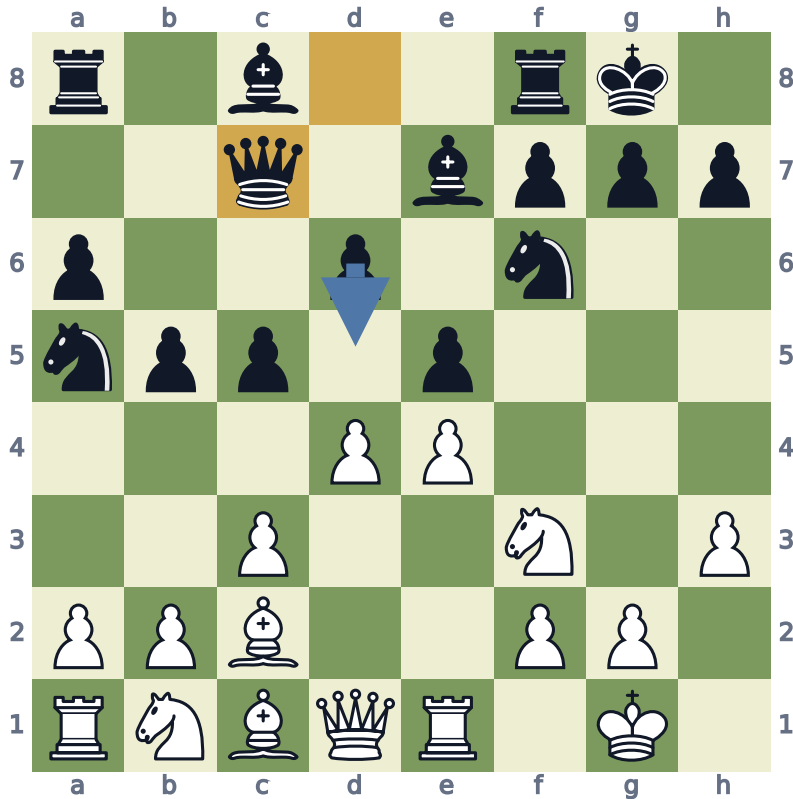
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Repairing Spanish theory from games



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SIDE TO MOVE

White

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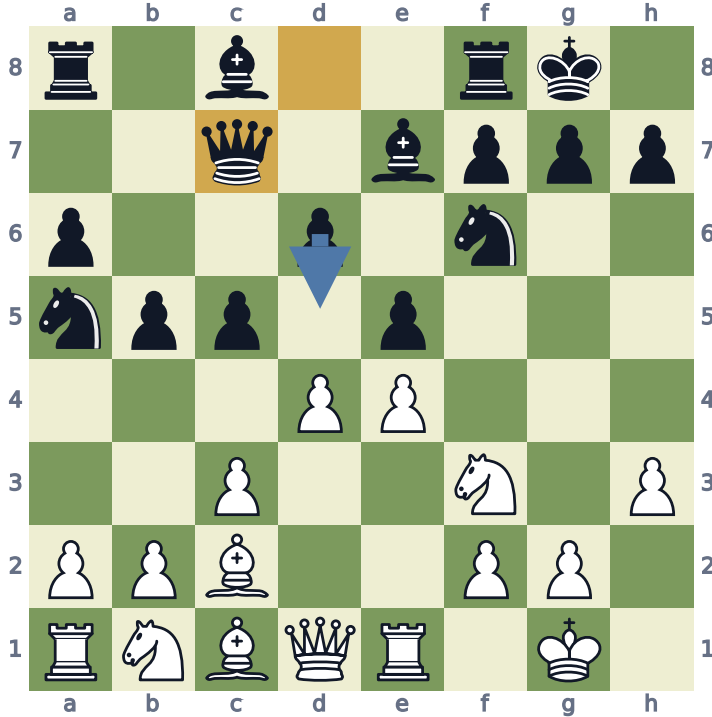
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

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FAILURE MODE

Replacing understanding with ever-longer files or abandoning the opening after one tactical loss.

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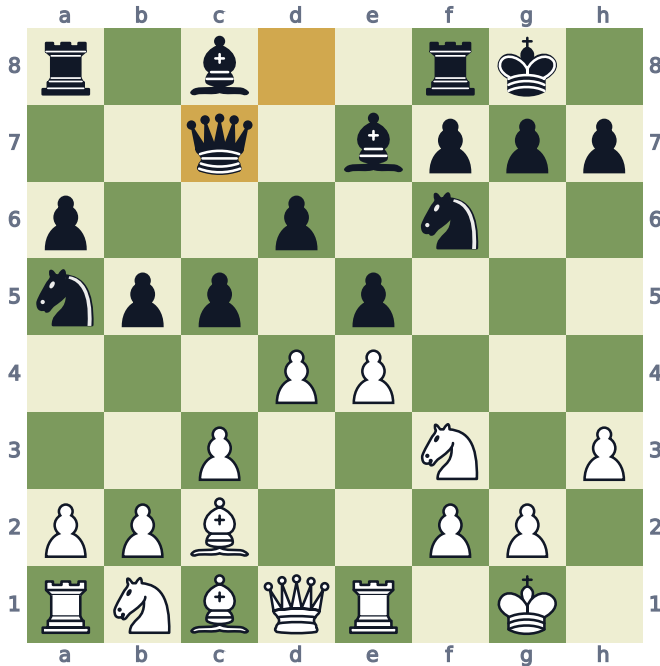
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7



- h3: White prevents a pin and supports the coming central plan at the cost of one tempo.
- Na5: Black reroutes a knight to a5; judge the move by the job at its destination and the time conceded on the way.
- Bc2: White changes a bishop's diagonal; identify the central pawn move that will make that diagonal useful.
- c5: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, weak squares, open lines, and king exposure.
- d4: White challenges e5 and opens lines after the preparatory pieces are ready.
- Qc7: Black coordinates several plans, but the queen's safety and the opponent's forcing reply must be checked.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

Because the Ruy Lopez branches deeply, efficient study begins at the first position where your plan became unclear, not at move one after every loss.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time? White's resource is: Use both colors in training so opponent resources become familiar plans rather than surprises. The line fails as a template when: Replacing understanding with ever-longer files or abandoning the opening after one tactical loss.

STORE THIS | Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White trying to achieve, and which piece or pawn enables it?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

1. Because the Ruy Lopez branches deeply, efficient study begins at the first position where your plan became unclear, not at move one after every loss. 2. Record the structure, candidate moves, and strongest opponent reply; add one corrected line and one verbal rule to the repertoire. 3. Use both colors in training so opponent resources become familiar plans rather than surprises. 4. At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time? 5. Replacing understanding with ever-longer files or abandoning the opening after one tactical loss.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 22 plies from memory, then replay: 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 103 Decode: White's main-plan rehearsal

Prompt: Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup?

Recall: *The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.*

LESSON 104 Play: White's main-plan rehearsal

Prompt: Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup?

Recall: *The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.*

LESSON 105 Decode: Black's defense-choice tree

Prompt: What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used?

Recall: *Every Spanish defense is a bargain; know both the asset and the debt.*

LESSON 106 Play: Black's defense-choice tree

Prompt: What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used?

Recall: *Every Spanish defense is a bargain; know both the asset and the debt.*

LESSON 107 Decode: Repairing Spanish theory from games

Prompt: At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time?

Recall: *Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.*

LESSON 108 Play: Repairing Spanish theory from games

Prompt: At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time?

Recall: *Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.*

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's plan, one candidate for the side to move, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

White's main-plan rehearsal

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Nb8 10. d4 Nbd7 11. Nbd2 Bb7 12. Bc2 Re8 13. Nf1 Bf8

Decision: Which preparatory move is still essential, and which can be omitted because Black changed the setup?

Memory: The Spanish plan is modular: keep the purpose, adjust the move order.

CARD 2

Black's defense-choice tree

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 O-O 8. c3 d5

Decision: What did Black gain, what permanent concession was made, and how must the gain be used?

Memory: Every Spanish defense is a bargain; know both the asset and the debt.

CARD 3

Repairing Spanish theory from games

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7 6. Re1 b5 7. Bb3 d6 8. c3 O-O 9. h3 Na5 10. Bc2 c5 11. d4 Qc7

Decision: At what move did you stop understanding the position, and what cue should trigger the correct plan next time?

Memory: Repair the first unexplained decision and rehearse it from both sides.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
103 Decode: White's main-plan rehearsal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
104 Play: White's main-plan rehearsal	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
105 Decode: Black's defense-choice tree	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
106 Play: Black's defense-choice tree	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
107 Decode: Repairing Spanish theory from games	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
108 Play: Repairing Spanish theory from games	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name both sides' strongest plans, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.